

South Korea: Tech-Driven Strong Rebound in August Exports

Bottom line:

Korea's headline exports increased 2.8% mom sa in August, rebounding from -2.5% the prior month. The outcome was stronger than our above-consensus forecast. Tech exports accelerated to 6.5%, helped by sustained strength in semiconductor exports and a rebound in other tech exports, whereas non-tech exports fell 1.5%. Exports to China and the US gained the most and accounted for the entire headline sequential increase. Imports fell 3.6% mom sa, contracting at a more rapid pace than the -1.8% in the prior month, and the trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) widened to US\$34.7bn, up from US\$30.4bn the prior month and nearing the historical high in June.

Key numbers:

August exports: +68.7% year-on-year; Bloomberg consensus: +63.0%; GS forecast: 64.6%; Previous: +63.0%.

August imports: +22.5% year-on-year; Bloomberg consensus: +25.0%; GS forecast: +22.3%; Previous: +26.5%.

August trade balance: US\$34.7bn; Bloomberg consensus: US\$30.1bn; Previous: US\$30.4bn

Asia-MAP scores:

Exports: +12 (4, +3)

Imports: -3 (3, -1)

Main points:

1. Korea's headline exports increased 2.8% mom sa in August (non-annualized, seasonally adjusted by GS), rebounding from -2.5% the prior month. In year-on-year terms, growth picked up to 68.7% from 63.0% the prior month. The outcome was stronger than our above-consensus forecast.
2. Tech exports accelerated to 6.5% mom sa, up from 3.3% the prior month. Semiconductor exports sustained robust momentum of 7.2%, with the rapid pace almost unchanged for the third consecutive month and alone accounting for all of the headline sequential increase ([Exhibit 2](#)). Other tech exports rebounded to +4.6% helped by strong computer exports. Non-tech exports fell 1.5%, albeit at a moderating pace. Exports of autos and auto parts dropped sharply by 25.7%, but the weakness was partly offset by gains in energy-related

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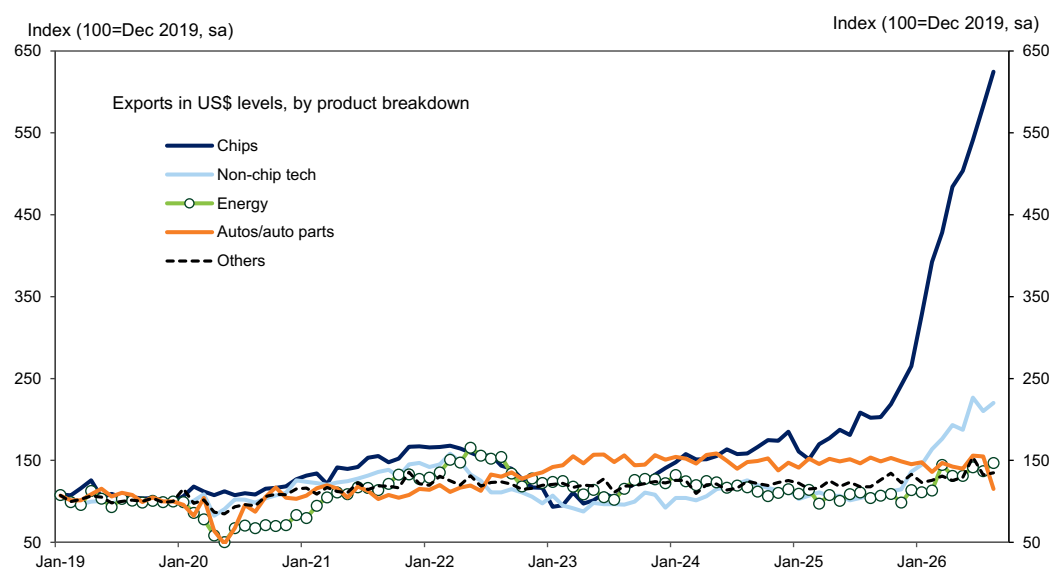
3. Exports to China and the US gained the most, by 9.5% and 6.7% mom sa, respectively, accounting for all of the headline sequential increase ([Exhibit 3](#)). Exports to Japan and ASEAN also gained modestly, by 1.2% and 3.0% respectively. However, some of the gains were offset by a 24.4% drop in exports to the EU.
4. Imports fell 3.6% mom sa, contracting at a more rapid pace than the -1.8% in the prior month. A sharp 19.0% pullback in energy-related imports accounted for the entire headline sequential decline. While imports of general machinery also fell, imports of semiconductor manufacturing equipment rose sharply further. In year-on-year terms, growth moderated to 22.5% from 26.5% the prior month, in line with our below-consensus forecast. The trade surplus (not seasonally adjusted) widened to US\$34.7bn, up from US\$30.4bn the prior month and nearing the historical high in June.

Exhibit 1: Rebound in August exports...

	Aug-26	Jul-26	Jun-26	May-26	Apr-26	Mar-26	Feb-26	Jan-26	Dec-25	Nov-25	Oct-25	Sep-25	Aug-25
Exports growth (% yoy)	68.7	63.0	70.4	52.9	47.8	50.4	29.4	33.9	13.3	7.9	3.5	12.6	1.1
(% 3m/3m sa)	14.4	15.1	18.2	19.5	22.1	18.7	15.2	9.8	8.9	6.0	4.9	2.5	3.0
(% mom sa)	2.8	(2.5)	12.6	2.1	3.1	9.1	7.9	4.2	8.9	(2.3)	5.5	3.1	(0.8)
Imports - % yoy	22.5	26.5	30.0	20.7	16.7	13.9	7.5	11.7	4.6	1.1	(1.5)	8.3	(4.1)
mom% sa	(3.6)	(1.8)	9.4	1.4	3.0	2.2	3.5	0.0	5.6	(3.9)	0.8	4.4	(0.5)
Trade balance - US\$bn	34.7	30.4	35.9	26.8	23.6	26.6	15.7	8.7	12.1	9.5	6.0	9.5	6.4
Memorandum item:													
Non-ship exports % yoy	78.2	63.6	72.9	54.4	47.9	52.7	29.0	35.7	14.1	9.5	(1.2)	12.2	0.5
% mom sa	5.1	(3.4)	13.3	1.5	4.3	8.4	8.2	3.8	8.6	0.9	4.8	2.8	(2.0)
Non-ship trade balance - US\$bn	34.7	27.1	33.1	24.2	20.7	23.1	13.5	6.2	9.1	7.6	1.3	6.6	3.3

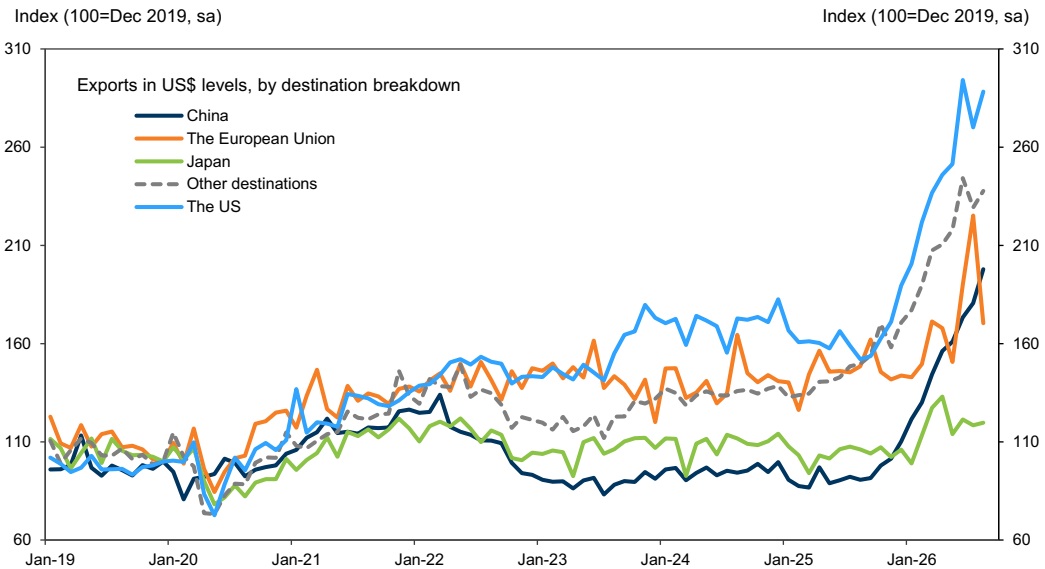
Source: Ministry of Trade, Industry and Resources

Exhibit 2: ... led by sustained strong gains in semiconductors...



Source: Ministry of Trade, Industry and Resources

Exhibit 3: ... and exports to China and the US



Disclosure Appendix

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